point towards my bureau officers to do the same job. When I objected to it, he told me, *'you keep quiet'*, as if I was a delinquent child speaking out of turn. I replied: '*May I know why, Sir? You just assured the home minister that you would take up the project. So please don't deplete my scanty resources.'* He did not listen to me; he had his way. The few who comprised the bureau leadership were present in both the meetings. They were left aghast at the happenings! How they wished they had not been present to witness these happenings. For they did not know whether to smile or cry and whose side to be on. They were caught in the crossfire between bosses!

This habit, not to be pressurized and enslaved by unreasonable behaviour, was enough for me to be ostracized even more.

I could have easily said, 'yes sir' or 'sure sir' and obliged the powers that be. And then I could have passed the buck on to my colleagues with the same insensitivity. I personally could have travelled the world over, as an understudy (as was suggested as bait). But I chose to stay focused on what was at hand and get that going without placing any more burden on my colleagues.

My initiatives to modernize and develop the bureau – opening up of the organization to the public by setting up the BPRD website (with the help of the National Informatics Centre, New Delhi) and holding regular meetings with registrars of various universities to encourage country-wide research on police and prison issues through their existing departments – were being construed by the higher-ups as 'challenging the system' yet again. It was for the first time (barring some failed efforts) an attempt was being made within India to provide access to police stations for research, hitherto considered totally out of reach (and still are) for the academics. Which is why we faced (and continue to suffer) a total drought of dynamic research in the area of criminal justice.

Surely, in the process, the BPRD was still the gainer. The organization received, from the Planning Commission of India, for the first time ever since independence 'planned funds' as against nothing since its inception. This accomplishment was made possible, thanks to our (my colleague Rakesh Jaruhar, director, training, and myself) prior meeting with Dr Montek Singh Ahluwalia, deputy chairman of the Planning Commission of India, and with the support of a new Union home secretary, Madhukar Gupta (son of an illustrious police officer of his time and from whom the service had very high hopes for police reforms). These funds would hopefully move the organization further towards fulfilling some of its futuristic goals. For me, this was a responsibility fulfilled. There was nothing more awaiting me except probably to continue serving as a 'back-end desk' for the 'controllers'.

* * *

I sought an appointment with Shivraj Patil, the then Union home minister. Sensing the urgency of my request, his office was gracious enough to grant me an audience.

On meeting the then home minister, I handed over to him my application seeking voluntary retirement, which read as follows:

Dear Sir:

Having served the last 35 years in the IPS with never-ending enthusiasm and commitment, I now wish to apply for voluntary retirement from the Service. This is to enable me to devote my entire time to the pursuit of my academic, creative and NGO interests.

I can assure you that even outside office, my commitment, respect and support for the cause of